but, as both teams travelled west for the second leg of the summer, a series in South Africa, the momentum was shifting in their favour.

The results don't lie.

The first Test at the Wanderers in Johannesburg: Australia won by 162 runs. The second Test at Kingsmead in Durban: Australia won by 175 runs. We were not being beaten at home; we were being thumped at home, and we travelled to Cape Town hoping to find some salvation, some crumb of consolation in the third Test at Newlands.

My personal form was decent (I had scored a century in Johannesburg), but I was being drawn into conflict with Ashwell Prince. We both wanted to bat at No. 5 but it had become clear one of us would be asked to open. The selectors decided I would keep the place in the middle order and an increasingly public rivalry boiled over the next weekend when we were playing against each other in a match between our respective provincial sides, the Titans and Western Province. Harsh words were spoken on both sides. I regretted the saga because I admired and respected Ashwell as an outstanding cricketer and as an outstanding man.

He responded in the best possible way. When we had dismissed the Australians for 209 in their first innings, he opened our reply and scored a fine century, turning the tide of the series. His efforts created a platform for me to play one of the most satisfying innings of my career. With Jacques Kallis moving serenely towards three figures, I walked out to bat on the second evening and aimed to drive home our advantage.

Saturday, 21 March 2009, dawns bright and sunny at Newlands. Resuming my innings on 39, I am especially keen to do well because I know my father is watching from his seat in the grandstand. He is working as a full-time GP back home in Bela-Bela, which means he rarely has time to watch cricket. However, on this particular day, the dates have worked out and he is here, and I want to impress him.

We lose two early wickets but I manage to survive, reach my hundred